# Rebuilding Memory at the Hatay Assembly Building

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**When a historic building returns, how much of the place we remember returns with it?**

## Meeting at the Assembly Building (Meclis)




29 November 2022. The assembly building before the earthquake, when it housed the Meclis Cultural and Arts Centre. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

Before the earthquake, I often sat near the assembly building, which we called the Meclis. “Let’s meet in front of the Meclis” was an ordinary way to arrange a meeting. I remember its years as a künefe restaurant and later its use as a culture and art centre. Meclis Künefe is documented in the building by November 2018; the restored cultural centre opened to the public on 23 July 2021 with an upstairs library. [2, 4] I remember a small museum display about Hatay joining the Republic of Turkey. We used to study in the library while I was still living in Antakya. These ordinary uses gave the building a place in my own life.

## Returning to the Damaged City



14 September 2023. The damaged assembly building behind metal fencing, photographed on my first return to central Antakya after the earthquake. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

The earthquakes of 6 February 2023 destroyed much of the assembly building. [3] On 14 September, I returned to central Antakya for the first time since the earthquake, after being displaced to Ankara. I had only been able to come back after months away. Seeing the Meclis, it felt as though the heart of the city was dead. The partly collapsed building seemed to sum up the city around it: rubble, destruction, and familiar places that were no longer whole. My photograph records what I encountered on that September visit, rather than the immediate aftermath of the earthquake.

## Rebuilding a Historic Landmark



17 September 2024. A crane and rising reinforcement bars show reconstruction underway at the assembly building site. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

The building's history reaches beyond my own memories. It was used by the Hatay State assembly in 1938, before Hatay's incorporation into Turkey in 1939. The district administration records the assembly's first three meetings at this Köprübaşı building. [1] Its reconstruction therefore carries a connection to political history as well as everyday life in Antakya. I moved back to Hatay in September 2024. That month, I photographed a crane and rising reinforcement bars where the damaged building had stood. The photograph shows construction underway on 17 September; it does not establish when reconstruction first began.

## The Street Around the Building



18 September 2024. The assembly building’s reconstruction site seen from Atatürk Caddesi, with damaged buildings and rubble nearby. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

From Atatürk Caddesi, the assembly building appears as part of a larger damaged setting. I remember this as one of Antakya’s busiest streets. In this photograph, cars pass the construction site, while rubble lies beside a damaged building opposite it. Looking only at the assembly building would leave out the streets through which people reached it. Its importance as a meeting point also depended on those familiar routes. This view shows the surroundings that were part of everyday life around the Meclis.

## The Familiar Shape Returns



12 December 2024. The curved frontage and columns become recognizable within the unfinished structure. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

By December, the rounded frontage and columns were recognisable again, although the structure remained unfinished. A December 2023 report described specialists sorting and numbering recovered mosaics, tiles, ceiling elements, and window and door frames, with sound pieces intended for reuse. [3] Reconstruction therefore raises questions about both familiar appearance and surviving material. My photographs show the building taking shape, but they cannot establish how much original material was eventually reused. The return of its familiar outline is one part of the story, alongside the work of recovering what could be saved.

## A Place Beside the River



12 December 2024. Reconstruction viewed across the river, with pedestrian railings in the foreground. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

Another photograph from the same day shows the building across the river. Railings and the water occupy much of the foreground. This view records the relationship between the Meclis and its surroundings rather than isolating its façade. The place I remember includes the spaces around the building where people could pass, wait or meet. Keeping those surroundings in the photographic record helps explain why the rebuilding of one structure can matter to people's sense of the city.

## Work Beyond the Façade




27 May 2025. Work continues around the assembly building, with excavators and mounds of earth and stone in the foreground. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

In May 2025, the rounded frontage had gained more of its recognisable detail. In front of it, machinery and mounds of earth and stone filled the area. This photograph shows that work extended beyond the assembly building itself. It also records an intermediate moment that a simple before-and-after comparison could miss. My photographs were taken months apart, so they form a personal record of visible change rather than a complete account of every construction stage. They preserve something of the time and work involved in rebuilding.

## Feeling at Home Again



26 April 2026. The rebuilt assembly building with its lights back on at night, its familiar curved balcony and columns visible again. Photograph © Yusuf Düzel.

When I saw the rebuilt assembly building in April 2026, I had tears of happiness. By then I was already living in Hatay again. Seeing its familiar form return made me feel that hope was still there and life was coming back. In a way, it felt like going back in time. It felt like home again. My photographs preserve the damaged and unfinished stages alongside that moment of recognition. Together, they connect the rebuilt building to what happened here and to the everyday memories that made it meaningful before the earthquake.

## Sources

The photographs and personal recollections are my own. Historical context is supported by the following sources, accessed last on 25 September  2026.

[1] Antakya Kaymakamlığı. “Meclis Binası.” 27 March 2026. https://www.antakya.gov.tr/meclis-binasi

[2] Hatay Valiliği. “Hatay Valiliği Meclis Kültür ve Sanat Merkezi ile Antakya Konağı’nın Açılışı Gerçekleştirildi.” 24 July 2021. https://www.hatay.gov.tr/hatay-valiligi-meclis-kultur-ve-sanat-merkezi-ile-antakya-konaginin-acilisi-gerceklestirildi

[3] Lale Köklü Karagöz and Mehmet Bayrak, Anadolu Ajansı. “Depremlerin yıktığı Hatay’daki tarihi meclis binası yeniden inşa edilecek.” 12 December 2023, updated 13 December 2023. https://www.aa.com.tr/tr/gundem/depremlerin-yiktigi-hataydaki-tarihi-meclis-binasi-yeniden-insa-edilecek/3080122

[4] Habertürk. “Tarihi Hatay Meclisi köfteci-künefeci oldu.” 15 November 2018. https://www.haberturk.com/tarihi-hatay-meclisi-kofteci-kunefeci-oldu-2221684

Sources [1] and [2] give differing accounts of where the final June 1939 vote on joining Turkey took place. This essay therefore describes the building’s early assembly use without locating that final vote inside it.

## AI Assistance

ChatGPT assisted with source searches, translation of the sources and English drafting. The photographs and personal memories are my own. No AI-generated images or invented historical evidence are included.

## Image Descriptions

1. 29 November 2022
   The assembly building's light stone façade, tall windows, curved balcony and columns. A Turkish flag flies beside it. Planting stands near a sign identifying the Meclis Culture and Arts Centre.
2. 14 September 2023
   The partly collapsed building behind corrugated metal fencing. Part of the rounded decorative façade and its supporting columns remains standing. A car is visible on the right.
3. 17 September 2024
   A yellow tower crane above a fenced construction site, with vertical reinforcement bars and formwork. Trees and a metal riverside railing frame the view.
4. 18 September 2024
   Atatürk Caddesi with cars, trees and tall streetlights. The assembly building's construction site and crane are on the left. Rubble lies beside a damaged building on the right.
5. 12 December 2024
   The unfinished building's rounded frontage, balcony and columns, surrounded by scaffolding and timber formwork. A crane extends across the sky above it.
6. 12 December 2024
   Pedestrian railings overlook the river in the foreground. Across the water, a crane stands above the unfinished assembly building and construction fencing.
7. 27 May 2025
   The partly finished building stands behind fencing. Mounds of earth and stone fill the foreground, with yellow excavators on either side.
8. 26 April 2026
   The rebuilt assembly building illuminated at night. Chandeliers are visible through tall windows behind the curved balcony. Columns frame the entrance, with small trees on the lawn in front.